

LIFE AND LEADERSHIP IN the Pacific



▲ Sound of music

The tone of the Maori putorino—a flutelike wooden instrument—was said to represent Hineraukatauri, a female ancestor spirit who personified music. Use of the putorino died out in the mid-1800s, but Maori musicians have begun to reintroduce it.

ISLAND TRADITIONS

The island cultures of the Pacific Ocean stretch back tens of thousands of years before European contact was first made. Migration to the islands started from Southeast Asia between 3000 and 1000 BCE. People first settled across Melanesia (from Papua New Guinea to New Caledonia, Fiji, Santa Cruz, Vanuatu, and the Solomon Islands), then Micronesia (Marshall Islands Palau and Mariana Islands), and finally the Polynesian islands (New Zealand, Tonga, Samoa, Tuvalu, Hawaii, Cook Islands, Marquesas Islands, French Polynesia including Tahiti and Bora Bora, and Easter Island).

Due to the remoteness of the islands, contact with other islands was infrequent and each island society flourished individually. However, although they grew into diverse cultures, many of the islands shared common gender roles. Men did most of the deeper sea fishing and cultivation of trees such as coconut and breadfruit, while women cultivated the land, did inshore fishing, and manufactured the valuables that were used for trade—loom-woven clothing, mats, medicine, and ornaments. The role of women in these groups was also to bear children and to teach and care for them in their formative years.

Female leaders

One commonality in Pacific societies is the lack of historical, written documentation on the everyday lives of women. When European contact first occurred, explorers expected to meet with male leaders and not women, and those who wrote about their encounters minimized the high rank and power women

held. In Pacific societies, rank and family lineage was the deciding factor in the distribution of political and social power.

In pre-contact Hawaii, for example, the status of women was higher than men. Women were chiefs as early as 1375, when Kukaniloko ruled Oahu.

Other island cultures also have long histories of female leadership. Before colonization, more than half of the recorded rulers of the island of Huaine (French Polynesia) were female, and Pōmare IV ruled Tahiti for 50 years as its last major monarch before the French took control.

Powerful women, however, were maligned by Europeans—for example, Tupoumoheofo, an 18th-century Tongan leader, was characterized as a scheming, tyrannical, “meddling wife.”

In 1890,
4 of 5
chiefs in
Rarotonga
were women.



▲ Polynesian skirt

This striking dancing skirt known as a *titi saka* was made in Tuvalu from pandanus leaf and plant fiber. The artistry used to make a dance costume is as important as the dance itself in the Pacific islands.